

can connect and share files between different computers at my home using just my Wi-Fi router. Hence, setting up a wireless network is a breeze!" Khalid confirms, "Business users also are going to find the networking features extremely handy as this makes sharing network

resources a cakewalk even for users with average computing skills." The new network security features, which help users control the access/visibility between various devices on the network, is also a value add, feels Khalid. Direct access to corporate network without the need of a

VPN connection; an AppLocker which can specify exactly what application can run on the users' desktops and virtual desktop infrastructure (VDI) optimisations are features that are apt to optimise organisational network resources and efficiencies, says Singh.

But comparisons are inevitable!

Despite the strong points, the OS still may have to fight a battle with other competing OSes, outside of the Microsoft camp, and also with its own predecessors, opine many experts. Here are a few considerations that may prove crucial in determining the OS success in the long run:

Will it be able to brave...

... *the XP.* Windows 7's biggest competitor will be XP, which still runs on about 80 per cent of PCs, the world over, feels Gupta. "The reason why most PCs are still running XP may have nothing to do with whether Windows 7 is 'good' or 'bad.' Windows XP may be old, but it gets the work done. Switching to Windows 7, regardless of its advantages, may be too much work and too much new stuff to learn," says Gupta.

For most people, "old and familiar" may be more comfortable than "new and improved." And if that is really the case, Windows 7 may not do any better than Vista, he adds.

... *the Mac OS.* Comparison with Apple's Mac OS X is also inescapable, if one talks about GUI (graphics user interface). Mody and Sukhija however feel that although the GUI has been made a lot simpler it cannot be classified as very innovative. In fact, it is 'tech-inspired' from Mac OS, Mody adds.

But Mody states an interesting point in favour of Windows 7. "Innovation comes in many shapes and forms. One needs to take into account that Microsoft managed these user enhancement tweaks while working with highest number of third party devices, which in itself is a huge achievement."

... *open source OSes.* The coming of Windows 7 will surely lead to OS com-

petitive landscape changes and will make Linux community try, again, to catch up with Microsoft, feels Sukhija.

"While open source OSes provide 80 per cent functionalities at 20 per cent price (though it is free, it needs installation, lots of research, etc; and here, I am taking time also as money), it provides the rest of the 20 per cent at 80 per cent of the cost, which includes cost of customer/maintenance support rendered by vendors in this space," he adds. Another issue is, application drivers compatible with open source OSes are also not easily available. Users may get stuck and may need to invest time in case they get stuck with a simple e-mail client-related problem and if forums do not help, points out Sukhija.

Khalid also seconds Sukhija's thoughts and adds, "Most of my must-have applications don't run on the BSD flavours, and that's a huge deterrent for corporate environments. I don't mind paying for an OS that is compatible with all my applications and all my hardware. Standardised support and maintenance also means something."

To upgrade or not to upgrade

Looking at the long list of exciting features and possibilities, there's no reason to refuse Windows 7 if you get it pre-installed on a new PC. Individual users who can afford to buy Windows 7, should certainly upgrade, says Mody. But for businesses, however, there is no 'one-great-feature' that makes it a compelling upgrade, feels Gupta. He states the reason too: "For enterprises, the cost of switching to a new OS is not just the licensing fees they have to pay. It will also mean

Hardware requirements

To help users, Microsoft has released an upgrade advisor that scans a computer to see if it is compatible with Windows 7. But for a tentative idea, Sukhija affirms that a system that is capable to run Windows XP at a good speed would be enough to run Windows 7 with average speed. "My system is Intel core2duo T5600 processor 1.7 GHz, having 1 GB RAM and 8MB graphics memory card and runs the OS smoothly. Even applications like Photoshop run fine even when there are other heavy applications running," he adds.

the added costs of hardware upgrade required to support the new OS. Not to mention, costs of training their workforce to use the new operating system.

Future projections

With over 1000 organisations in India having made a transition to Windows 7 already, the elation at the Microsoft camp is well justified. The overall market share of Windows 7 has already exceeded that of Mac OS and Linux combined, reveals Gupta.

Considering these statistics, Windows 7 looks all set to surpass all Microsoft OS deployment statistics. The real question that still remains unanswered is whether Windows 7 will get the majority that is still on XP. And that is a space that Microsoft would be watching closely too!

From the technologists' and IT industry perspective too, the future certainly seems to hold many promises and opportunities. Many projections and predictions are already making rounds. But how many of these will turn real, is something that only time will tell in due course. However, it will certainly be more interesting to watch developments in this space! ●

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